(religious decree) was considered law. Now these men brought forward the case of Shirazi, a Persian Shia, who had died the previous year and was buried in the neighbourhood of the famous Delhi poet, Amir Khusro. The ulema maintained that being a Hindustani Sunni, Khusro would ‘be very much annoyed’ by the posthumous company of Shirazi, ‘a native of Iraq and a heretic’. Akbar agreed to these demands and had Shirazi dug up and buried elsewhere, an act which Badauni himself, usually orthodox in matters of religion, found ‘was a great act of injustice to both of them’. During this decade, it is clear that Akbar acquiesced to a repressive attitude towards all Muslim sects which were condemned by the orthodox Muslims as heretical. Badauni meanwhile had spent most of the decade in the employ of Shaikh Hussain Khan, once Governor of Lahore. Hussain Khan had one day stood up to greet a visitor, not realizing that he was a Hindu, not a Muslim. Enraged at having shown an ‘infidel’ this passing courtesy, Hussain Khan ordered that Hindus stitch a patch of cloth, or tukra, of a different colour near the bottom of the sleeve so that they could be distinguished easily from Muslims and he would not inadvertently honour a Hindu. Having thus earned the sobriquet ‘Tukriya’, when Hussain Khan was transferred to Rohilkhand, a demotion, he retaliated by raiding Hindu temples and appropriating their hidden treasures to make up for his diminution of pay. This spirit of casual intolerance and bigotry was by no means uncommon at the time and Akbar, as he gauged his many challenges and especially the dangerous one from Mirza Hakim, preferred to keep the ulema pacified for the time being. When Akbar would finally confront the ulema, the fall of these men would be spectacular, the theologians completely unaware for many years of the true nature of the Padshah’s spiritual quest.

After the Uzbeks had been crushed in the east, many of the disgruntled survivors simply relocated to the prosperous sultanate of Gujarat, counting on its ruler for support and patronage. Akbar realized that the time would come when he would have to confront this powerful province, too, but between the Padshah’s territory and Gujarat lay an arid country filled with indomitable warriors, Rajasthan. Akbar, therefore, immediately after subduing the Uzbeks decided to attack a legendary fort that had never been taken. Its legacy was intertwined with his own Mughal ancestry but it was famously associated with one of the greatest warriors of the era, long dead but still revered—Rana Sangha. ‘One eye was lost in a broil with his